



# FINAL REPORT

Level Up Summer 2023

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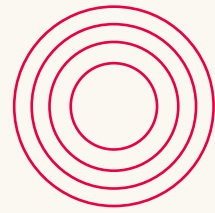
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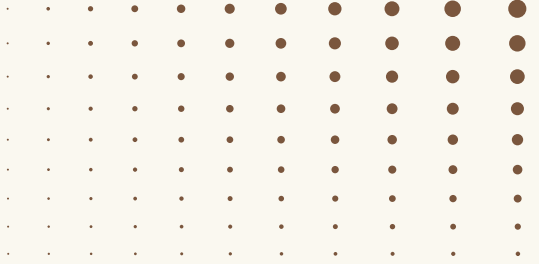
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## Fostering A Culture of

# Sustainability

### Mission

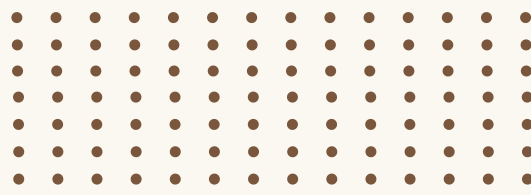
*This final report highlights our endeavors to further askBelynda, a sustainable shopping-focused business in its pursuit to extend its work in creating a culture of sustainability among companies.*

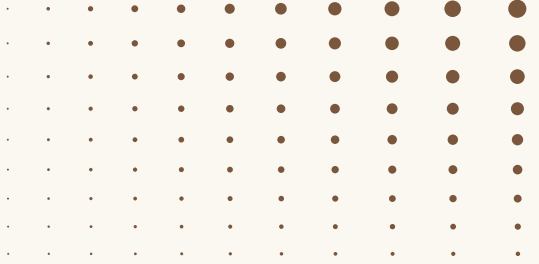
*Our primary goal was to extend our reach to businesses and collaborate with them to drive positive environmental and social impact through their operations and practices.*

## What is A Culture of Sustainability?

In today's business world, having a strong organizational culture is essential for success. It's all about having a shared set of beliefs and values that guide how a company operates and connects with its employees and customers. Recently, the importance of having a sustainability culture in businesses has been growing rapidly, catching the attention of both employees and customers.

A sustainability culture means focusing on making a positive impact in the long run, rather than just seeking short-term gains. It's about caring for the well-being of employees, the community, and the planet, and also considering long-term financial results.





## Understanding Our

# Target Employee

### Meet Mike

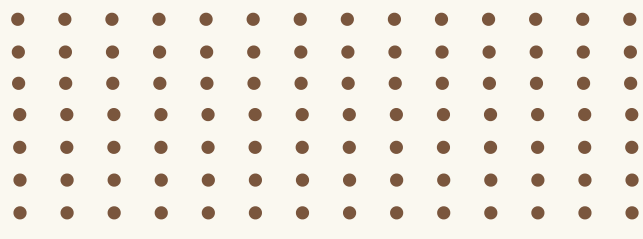
*Let's introduce Mike, a young professional working in a mid-sized company, who's invested in sustainability. He loves that his company is trying to be more eco-friendly by recycling office supplies and encouraging energy-saving practices.*

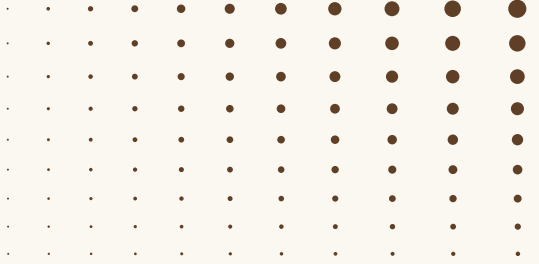
*But he thinks they can do even better by making more sustainable purchases. Turns out, Mike is not alone – many employees, especially millennials, are increasingly interested in sustainability initiatives at work.*

### The Situation

Mike's company is considered a level 2 in sustainability. They've taken some steps towards being greener, but they haven't fully embraced a comprehensive sustainability approach yet. To move up to level 3 and beyond, businesses like Mike's can get help from tools like AskBelynda's browser add-on, which finds sustainable shopping options.

Working with sustainability consultants can also guide companies in setting goals, tracking their environmental impact, reducing waste, and managing energy usage to become more sustainable.





## Understanding Our

# Target Employee

Even though Mike's company is at level 2, the workplace environment is positive and engaging. Studies show that sustainability initiatives can boost productivity, enhance a company's reputation, drive innovation, and make the workplace culture even better.

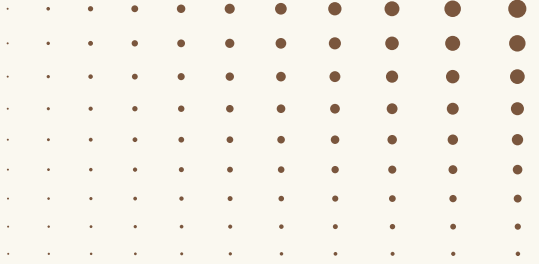
Of course, there are challenges on the road to sustainability. Rising supply costs, supply chain shortages, and geopolitical issues can be hurdles. But despite these challenges, many companies, including Mike's, are committed to investing in green alternatives to keep pushing sustainability forward.

Mike is also learning about stakeholder primacy theory, realizing that focusing solely on profits can harm the environment and society. Adopting a more sustainable business model is crucial because businesses can't ignore the impact they have on the world. Mike can take simple yet impactful steps to create a greener workplace. Embracing the AskBelynda extension and other sustainability initiatives not only benefits the planet but also creates a more positive working environment. After all, a greener workspace aligns with what employees want in their ideal working environment.

Embracing sustainability is the way to succeed in today's world. Companies like Mike's have the power to lead by adopting sustainable practices, reducing their environmental impact, and fostering a positive workplace culture that resonates with employees and customers alike.

By making sustainability a core value, businesses can ensure their long-term prosperity and contribute to a better and more sustainable future for everyone.





## Criteria for a Workplace's Culture

# Classification

### How We Classify Culture

*In order to understand and assess the sustainability practices and commitments of various workplaces, a set of comprehensive criteria can be utilized to classify their respective cultures. These criteria encompass different*

*aspects of sustainability, and each plays a pivotal role in shaping a workplace's sustainability orientation. The following elements will later be used to categorize companies into 5 different levels of sustainability.*

### Shared Values & Beliefs:

A workplace's culture can be classified based on the shared values and beliefs that guide the actions and decisions of its employees. This includes the importance of sustainability, environmental responsibility, employee well-being, community impact, and long-term thinking.

### Employee Engagement:

The level of employee engagement and involvement in sustainability initiatives is a crucial aspect of a workplace's culture. This includes employee awareness and understanding of sustainability goals, opportunities for participation and innovation in sustainable practices, and recognition of individual and collective efforts toward sustainability.



# Classification

## **Leadership & Communication:**

A workplace's culture can be classified based on the shared values and beliefs that guide the actions and decisions of its employees. This includes the importance of sustainability, environmental responsibility, employee well-being, community impact, and long-term thinking.

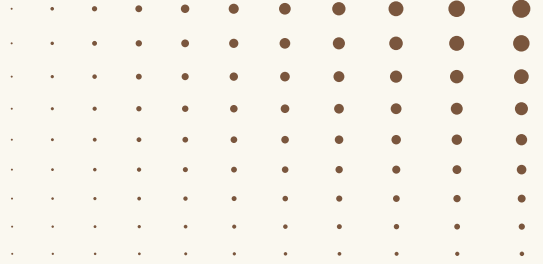
## **Systems & Policies:**

The culture of a workplace can also be assessed by the systems and policies in place to support sustainability practices. This includes the presence of environmental management systems, sustainable supply chain practices, waste reduction measures, energy efficiency initiatives, employee wellness programs, and dedicated directors of sustainability who play a vital role in overseeing and driving the company's sustainability efforts. These systems collaborate with various departments to develop and implement sustainable strategies, set measurable goals, ensure compliance with environmental regulations, and facilitate continuous improvement in the organization's sustainability practices.

## **Stakeholder Relationships:**

A workplace's culture can also be determined by the nature of its relationships with stakeholders, such as suppliers, customers, local communities, and regulatory bodies. This includes collaboration with stakeholders on sustainability initiatives, transparency in reporting environmental and social impacts, and responsiveness to stakeholder concerns and expectations.





## Workplace Sustainability

# Levels

### Level 1

#### Minimal Awareness

The workplace has limited awareness of sustainability issues and minimal efforts to integrate sustainability practices. There is a lack of shared values and minimal or no policies or systems to address sustainability concerns.

### Level 2

#### Compliance

The workplace recognizes the importance of sustainability due to legal or regulatory requirements. It has implemented basic sustainability practices to meet compliance obligations, such as waste management, energy conservation, or workplace safety measures.

### Level 3

#### Integration

The workplace actively integrates sustainability into its operations and decision-making processes. It adopts comprehensive sustainability policies, implements systems for tracking and reporting environmental impacts, and engages employees in sustainability initiatives.

### Level 4

#### Innovation

The workplace demonstrates a commitment to continuous improvement and innovation in sustainability practices. It encourages creativity and experimentation to develop new approaches that drive positive environmental and social impacts. This may involve collaboration with external partners, implementing advanced technologies, and seeking opportunities for sustainable product/service innovation.

### Level 5

#### Leadership and Influence

The workplace sets industry benchmarks for sustainability and strives to be a leader in its sector. It goes beyond compliance and actively influences and inspires other organizations to adopt sustainable practices. It engages in thought leadership, collaborates with stakeholders, and demonstrates a holistic approach to sustainability across its entire value chain.



# Levels

### How askBelynda Can Identify the Levels

*In order to effectively support businesses in their sustainability journey, askBelynda should employ various methods to identify companies at different levels of sustainability. A comprehensive*

*approach will enable askBelynda to tailor its services and guidance to meet the specific needs of each business, fostering continuous improvement and progress towards higher levels of sustainability.*

### Self Assessment:

askBelynda can provide companies with an online self-assessment questionnaire or survey that covers different aspects of sustainability. The tool may include a questionnaire covering different aspects of sustainability, allowing companies to assess their level of awareness, compliance, integration, innovation, or leadership. The questionnaire can inquire about current practices, policies, and goals related to environmental impact, employee well-being, community engagement, and financial considerations. Based on the responses, askBelynda can evaluate the company's sustainability level.

# Levels

### **Data Analysis:**

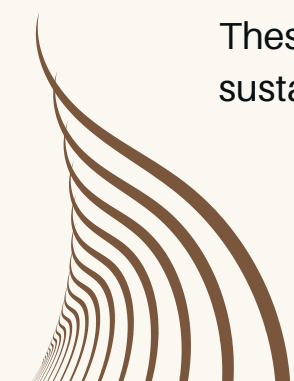
askBelynda employs a meticulous approach to sustainability assessment by delving into publicly available data and information about the company. This includes scrutinizing sustainability reports, corporate social responsibility disclosures, and environmental impact statements. Through comprehensive data analysis, askBelynda gains valuable insights into the company's sustainability efforts, examining key performance indicators, environmental practices, employee well-being initiatives, and community engagement efforts.

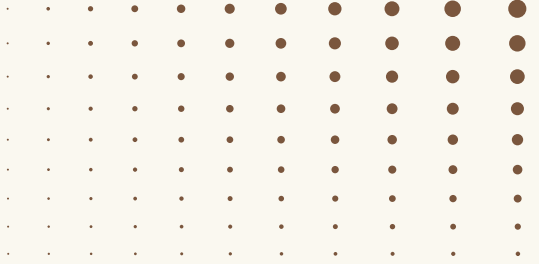
### **Engagement & Consultation:**

Through direct engagement and consultation with company representatives, askBelynda can gather information about their sustainability practices, initiatives, and goals. This can involve discussions, interviews, and collaboration to gain a comprehensive understanding of the company's sustainability culture.

### **External Ratings & Certifications:**

In its pursuit of a comprehensive sustainability assessment, askBelynda takes into consideration external ratings and certifications obtained by businesses. These third-party validations, such as ESG (Environmental, Social, and Governance) ratings, LEED (Leadership in Energy and Environmental Design) certification, or B Corp certification, offer valuable insights into a company's sustainability performance. These external validations can provide insights into a company's sustainability efforts and help place them on the scale.





## The Importance of Sustainability

# In Business

### Why is a Culture of Sustainability Important?

*Sustainable business practices offer numerous avenues for increasing profits, providing both financial and reputational benefits. By embracing sustainability, companies can tap into several lucrative opportunities:*

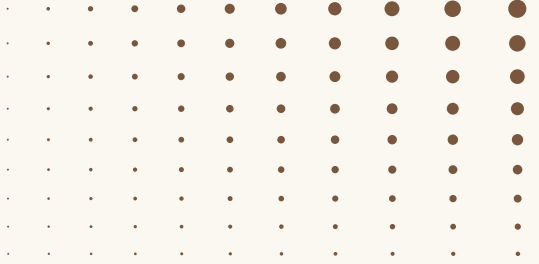
#### Strengthened Reputation & Customer Loyalty:

Businesses that prioritize sustainability enjoy a stronger reputation, which can translate into increased profitability. Studies by EY reveal that companies with higher environmental, social, and governance (ESG) performance experience a 4.8% higher return on equity compared to those with weak ESG performance. A solid reputation for sustainability enhances customer trust and loyalty, ultimately leading to higher profits as consumers are more likely to choose sustainable brands over others.

#### Access to Diverse Financing Options:

Sustainable businesses often have enhanced access to financing options, such as socially responsible investors, green bonds, and government grants. This increased availability of capital empowers companies to expand their operations, invest in sustainable infrastructure, and ultimately strengthen their profits.





## The Importance of Sustainability

# In Business

### **Enhanced Efficiency & Productivity**

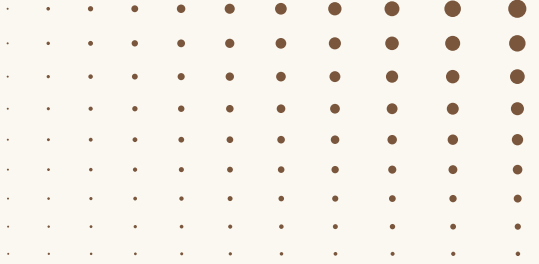
Sustainable businesses tend to exhibit higher efficiency compared to traditional ones. This efficiency stems from various factors, including the use of technology, renewable energy sources, waste reduction practices, and improved supply chain management. Happier employees, motivated by their company's sustainability efforts, are more likely to be engaged and productive, further contributing to increased efficiency and, consequently, profitability.

### **Cost Savings Through Efficiency:**

Sustainable business practices enable companies to manage their resources more efficiently. By investing in energy efficiency measures, businesses can significantly reduce energy bills, with potential savings of up to 20%, as demonstrated by research conducted by the Carbon Trust. Furthermore, waste reduction strategies help save money on disposal fees and decrease the need for purchasing new materials. Sustainable water management also contributes to cost reduction, particularly in areas like water supply and treatment. These cost savings can be substantial, benefiting a company's bottom line.

### **Attracting a New Market Segment:**

Embracing sustainability attracts environmentally and socially responsible consumers. This emerging market segment is willing to pay a premium for eco-friendly products and services. As a result, sustainable businesses can charge higher prices for their offerings, leading to increased revenue. Unilever's Sustainable Living Brands serve as a remarkable example, contributing to over 70% of the company's growth, highlighting the potential for sustainable practices to drive profits.



## How Sustainability Interacts with

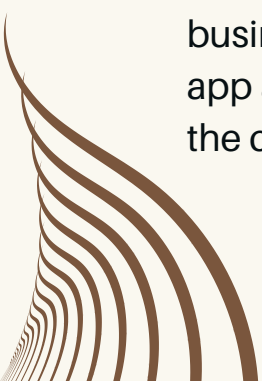
# Demographics

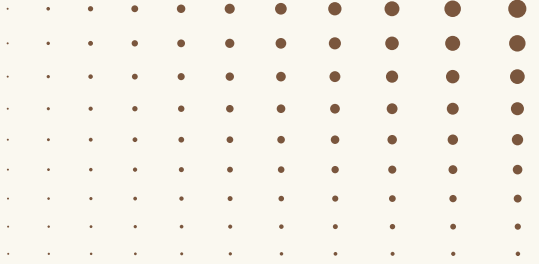
### Why it Matters

*Furthermore, besides the criteria, methods, and the level categorization for determining ask belyndas' commitments towards its clients. Such as allocating resources, services, and solutions that are both promoted by both employers and employees, so that both can reach a long term culture of sustainability. Is that of the impacts that demographics have on future workforce projections that will be influenced by associates who emphasize a greater value-oriented work culture, rather than one based on income. Simultaneously this will come as a growing number of states are looking to combat climate change through regulatory policy decisions in pushing companies towards adopting long term sustainable workplace policies and initiatives that have not been seen from past generations.*

### Impacts | Age Group

 Jason is a recent early 20 year old graduate from the University of California Berkeley on a Bachelor's degree in business management. He has been accepted for a fellowship program with a company that manages office supplies in the city of San Francisco. Even though he is excited and honored to be given the opportunity, Jason is worried about his potential employer practicing unsustainable workplace and business practices. With that, Jason decides to pull up the askBelynda app and look up the three main impacts from and on demographics for the culture of sustainability from his new employer..



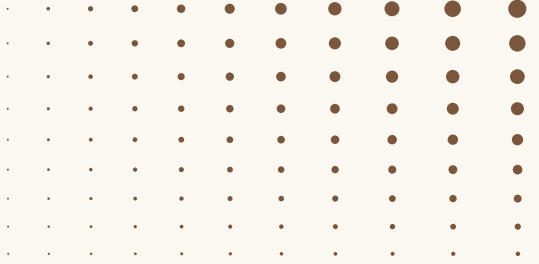


## How Sustainability Interacts with

# Demographics

The importance for Jason's case is that he is part of an ever growing pool of future employees who share worsening concerns of companies continuing business practices that are worsening the threat of climate change. Especially as both Millennials and Generation Z will become the largest working age cohort within 2 years time. As for the way younger generations will impact the culture of sustainability is that for the coming decades, these two age groups that Jason is a member of will not only be our clients' largest share of employees, but also their customers. For Instance, under a study by Cone Communications, Jason represents 51% of employees who would refuse to work for a company that doesn't enact effective and long-term social or environmental policies (or 83% of millennials and 75% of Generation Z) (Tenny, M., 2022). This becomes further impacted by the fact that, Jason is part of a growing pool of future employees who are willing to put their values to the test, by compromising their salaries for a more sustainable work culture (Harris, 2020)

Yet, just as Jason looks over how his age group has impacted his new area of occupation, he will also understand that he will also be impacted by the culture of sustainability in the company his fellowship will take place. Which will make his work experience a cooperative endeavor that will need a unified and consistent practice of values, engagement, and self assessment. Where any personal changes are made in reaching an expression of the culture of sustainability, this makes it that Jason's values will be consistently exemplified towards and by his colleagues by the decisions made by his future bosses.



## How Sustainability Interacts with

# Demographics

But also by making sustainable consumption and lifestyle choices, he could recommend askBelynda's product placement information of his new employer through their phone app, which will only further a growing trust of our clients, employees and customers reliability and accuracy on the environmental impacts of the products they sell and use.

For instance, even at the height of the Covid-19 Pandemic, two thirds of customers were still willing to spend more on sustainable products, (1.4 percent inflation to 8.5 percent) (of which 80% are young adults 18-34 years old). Yet, the biggest obstacle for companies is that most Americans still don't trust on the advertisement of corporations, due to the fearing environmental lies or fraud, also known as Green Washing (Fring, 2021)

From this, a potential area of product placement and marketing that Jason's employer could accept is that of askBelynda providing recommendations for policies and initiatives in working with non profit organizations. This will not only help in increasing workplace awareness of organizations that look to combat the negative societal problems that come with climate change. But also it will make a long term environmental impact on his company, as growing use of product placement and data analysis will allow his company's reputation, which will help in assisting askBelynda, on which level categorization should Jason's potential employer be placed at in receiving our services and support. For example, one organization that can be used in assisting Jason's employer in making greater integration with non profit organizations, especially for those that are looking to advance from level 2 to level 3. Is that of Giving Green, a charity that i offering programs that look towards carbon capture, and with assistance from his employer they are able to expand their operations (Meyer, 2020)



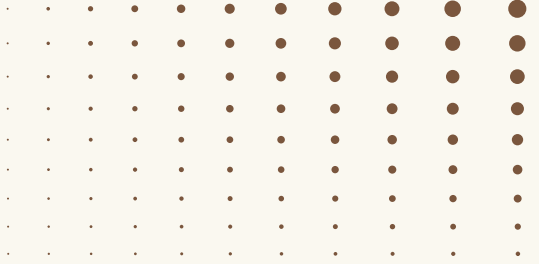
# Demographics

### Impacts | Location

Just as he looks over on how his age group can make a long term impact on his fellowship's culture of sustainability in integrating his values into their business model. However, Jason also sees on askBelynda's app, where even though he and his future colleagues have some influence in future decisions of his employers. The locations that are up to high standards of environmental efficiency that share similar beliefs to Jason's, also known as Green Buildings, are normally concentrated within major or minor metropolitan areas in the United States. Nevertheless, these types of buildings would be within our level 3-4 level categorization of the culture of sustainability, as they continued to grow in share of office space in the US since the year 2000. From this, Jason could recommend the askBelynda app to his new fellowship in San Francisco on future policy recommendations that they could voluntarily make for initiatives and workplace cultural practices, to gain greater reputations with rewards such as the LEED certification.

This is important as Jason's home state of California is 4th of the top 10 states with land area per sq feet LEED certified. This represents over a quarter of all 353 million gross sq ft land area under LEED 96,457,139 sq ft (2.44 sq ft per capita) 353 million sq ft (386 projects). An advantage to this is that there is a greater chance that Jason's new employer has either received or is on the cusp of receiving an LEED certification, and as the state's landmass continues to be certified, they will seek out more value oriented employees. As more than half of respondents believe that sustainable workplace culture and practices should be the main priority for Chief Executive Officers in value creating companies (39% in nonvalue creating ones) (McKinsey, 2021).



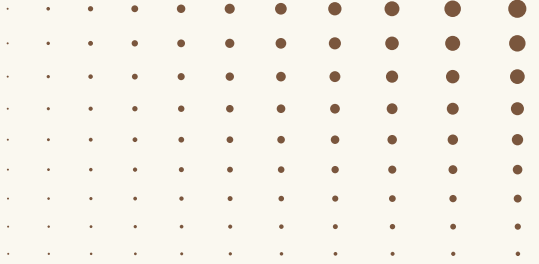


## How Sustainability Interacts with

# Demographics

Furthermore, Jason's new employer could also use the askBelynda app in narrowing down their policies, as employees who are value creators look for companies with clear priorities, defined targets, and key performance indicators, all at 41%, 50%, and 39% respectively. In the case of Jason, as a value creator, through ask belynda's subscriptions, he is able to influence his companies policies through customer outreach. As he would look to work in a company that looks to gain input (44% vs. 28%), the sustainable attributes of his companies products are marketed (59% vs. 37%), and the information of their products are provided by the company (41% vs. 26%) (McKinsey, 2021).

As for the impacts that culture of sustainability will have on locations within the United States is that as the growth in "green" land continues to be expanded under current and future projects by office buildings. They will be faced with a precarious situation in which companies that are either unable or unwilling to make the necessary policy decisions and initiatives that not only are able to retain employees, but could lead to greater loss in trust and reliability from their customers. Yet, the benefit that Jason's employers have with askBelynda is that due to the variety in our policy recommendations that we are able to provide, this company has the ability to gain the services and support that is generally not accepted by others, as long as they make a committed and consistent effort in reaching a culture of sustainability. This in result helps in obtaining data analyses and marketing recommendations from public sources, that helps in jumpstarting their process in level categorization.



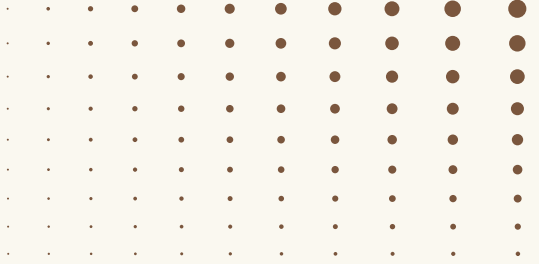
## How Sustainability Interacts with

# Demographics

For Jason, one advantage has over other competitors for this career position is that of California's major influence in the share of LEED buildings that are certified. The benefit to "green buildings" is that they are not only the most secure after implementing long term policies for obtaining a culture of sustainability. But on average the rent in green buildings is 31% more valued than non-certified ones. With that, if Jason ever decided to take up his fellowship in San Francisco after his potential employer decided to take up askBelynda's recommendations for a sustainable workplace culture. He would work in an office building that is not only younger on average (39 vs. 46), but with the likelihood of a higher chance of renovations (40% vs. 35%) and rentable area space for potential partners and clients (314,000 SF vs. 110,000 SF) (CBRE, 2022)

## Impacts | Regulation

Lastly, the reason as to why more companies are obtaining LEED certification is that of the growing number of companies facing regulatory constraints from state policy decisions on green buildings. With that, askBelynda to recommend its clients to construct policy that is able to meet state regulations, while also meeting the needs of their employees. As the decisions made by lawmakers could influence employers in negotiating future initiatives that would be a business policy compromise between lawmakers and a future value oriented workforce. As a result of these legal pressures, askBelynda, could recommend Jason's employer to set up 5 to 10 year initiatives in obtaining innovation and influence in local communion with a politically active workforce. Especially as the number of state and local jurisdictions that have passed legislation advancing green building regulations totaling 33 (bipartisan budget \$1.8 billion) as of 2022.

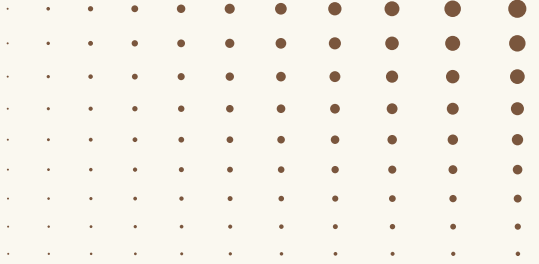


## How Sustainability Interacts with

# Demographics

A major catalyst to the growing use of legal incentives by lawmakers in pressuring companies, like Jason's employer in compromising profits for values, is that of the case of Washington DC. After their city council voted on the Clean Energy DC Omnibus Act in 2022, this would cut their gas emissions by half in 2032. Plus, with the help of the Clean Building Green Energy Performance Standard, half of all buildings in the city would be green by 2030. For Jason's employer, they could construct initiatives on certification goals towards measuring and distributing the amount of land area in sq ft of office space that can be made certified within a 5 year span. As places like DC, where a system was created in designating certain buildings with both historic and environmental value to those exceeding 50,000 square feet and also environmental for those exceeding 10,000 feet (Low & Goodrich, 2022)

This may also help Jason in deciding to take up this potential fellowship with his employer, by looking on the askBelynda app on how his state regulatory decisions have influenced the policy decisions and initiatives of his potential employer. Such as in the case of the City of Los Angeles, the Executive Director of the Los Angeles Chapter of the United States Green Building Council, Ben Stapleton. Has become a leading figure in making California one of the three leading states along with Colorado and Virginia in Green, culminating several hundred projects each as of 2022 (such as in Colorado going from a handful to 172 in 2022) (Hennick, 2021).

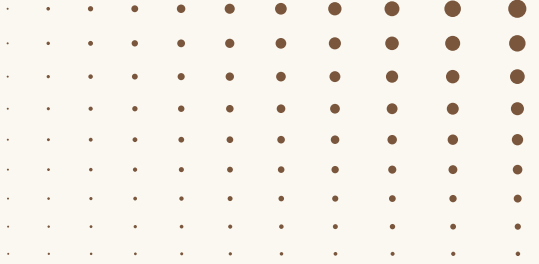


## How Sustainability Interacts with

# Demographics

Lastly, one important aspect that will impact Jason's ability to work in a more valued oriented workplace is that of his ability to compromise housing with income. As much of the younger generation is already an age group that is at a financial disadvantage compared to previous ones (even as they test their values against a company's salary). Yet an impact that sustainability culture will have on Jason's employer, is that as the suggestions that ask belynda provides will help in providing a sustainable and consistent road map towards level categorization. They may be able to construct policy and negotiate with lawmakers in describing the green buildings as not only more profitable, efficient, and sustainable compared to conventional ones. But also these types of buildings can be used as a policy solution towards the current housing crises in the United States, that many individuals in Jason's generation currently struggle with.

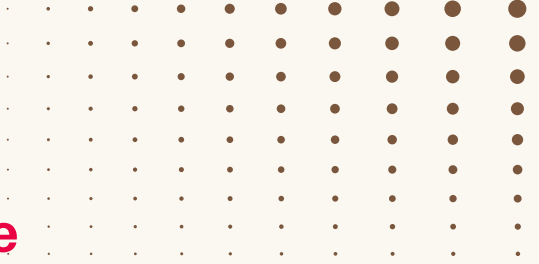
This will become ever important, as the availability of low income housing is becoming more scarce each year in this country, as upwards of 62% of Americans spend more than half of their income on rent (O' Shaughnessy, 2021). However, green certification can help state and local jurisdiction in circumventing bureaucratic limitations of the Housing Act of 1949, where as a result of a legacy of racism, there is an inequity in housing, both in quality and health, as a greater share of people of color will be affected by environmental degradation.



## How Sustainability Interacts with

# Demographics

In the case of Jason, even though Los Angeles may be a racial diverse city, on the national average, people of color are twice as likely to be affected by toxic waste disposal and pollution. Then compared to non-Hispanic White, even though they make up around 24% of the American Population (O' Shaughnessy, 2021). Yet, if Jason's employer is able to innovate and become an influential leader in their local community, then many of his values that he and his future colleagues share will be needed in constructing policy and initiative. For instance, a level 5 company has both the leadership and influence to partner with nonprofit organizations such as HOPE Village Inc. in Detroit Michigan. A revitalization project in the city urban center that looks to provide income and energy equity to the historically underserved African American communities, after an initiative passed in the state in 2016 (O' Shuaghnessy, 2021). This not only gives Jason's employer a partner in constructing policy for long term sustainability, but would become the leaders who influence others towards values similar to his.



## How Sustainability Improves Employee

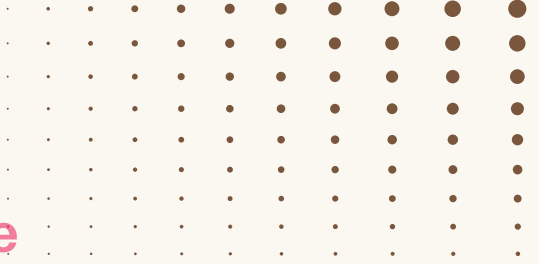
# Retention

### Why it Matters

*Employees who work for a company that cares about sustainability feel a stronger sense of purpose in their work, knowing that they are contributing to something meaningful and larger than themselves. Sustainable practices, like the addition of askBeylnda to your brand, can be an essential factor in attracting top talent. Many individuals actively seek opportunities to work for companies that prioritize sustainability, and once onboard,, they are more likely to stay with the company long-term. Everyone will benefit when a company is utilizing sustainable practices. This is far more desirable to have a stakeholder centric business model versus a shareholder centric model.*

### Stakeholder Business Model

The stakeholder theory highlights how crucial it is to take into account the needs and interests of all stakeholders who are touched by or have a say in the actions and decisions of the firm. The stakeholder model adopts a more thorough and inclusive approach than the conventional shareholder-centric model, which places the interests of shareholders (owners) above everyone else. Being a company that prioritizes improving the lives of everyone that the business touches is what the stakeholder business model is all about. Caring for the people, planet, and profits all simultaneously is possible!



## How Sustainability Improves Employee

# Retention

*Here is a list of different stakeholders that will benefit from sustainability efforts:*

**Employees** | People who work for the company and devote their time and talents to making it successful.

**Customers** | vote with their dollar, purchase the company's goods or services and are crucial to its ability to generate income.

**Suppliers** | Companies or people that provide the items or services that a firm needs to run.

**Investors** | People or groups who have contributed money to the business and hold ownership holdings.

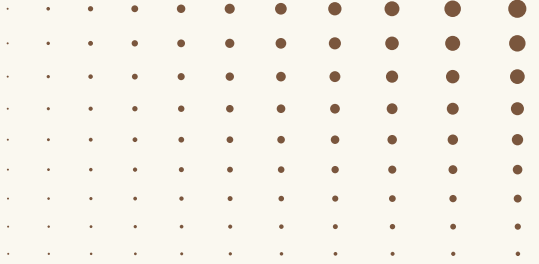
**Communities** | The regional communities in which the firm conducts business, which are impacted by its actions and may have an impact on its reputation.

**Government and Regulators** | Bodies that make laws and rules impacting how businesses are run.

**Non-Governmental Organizations (NGOs)** | Outside groups that are concerned with social and environmental concerns and could promote ethical corporate conduct.

**Public and Media** | The general public and the media, whose opinions and representations of the business significantly impact the business's reputation.





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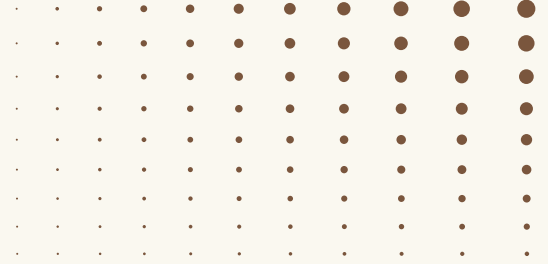
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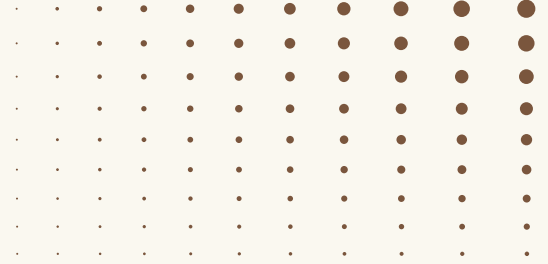
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